resounding defeat on them. She wanted to conclusively decimate the Mughals through a surprise night attack but her councillors, fatally, refused. Inevitably, as anticipated by the rani, they were then outnumbered by the cresting Mughal forces as many of her subordinate rajas defected to the enemy. In the end, when the troops were fighting hand to hand, with the rani's men dying in gallant numbers beside her, and as the arrows began to thud into the rani herself as she directed operations from her war elephant, she decided that to flee this scene of defeat would be a dishonour she could not live with. Rani Durgavati gauged the span and heft of her glory and all that she stood to lose, and killed herself with her dagger and her vast lands and enormous treasure fell to the Mughal Empire.

When Asaf Khan then took the neighbouring Chauragarh fortress, defended to the death by the rani's son, as gallant as his mother, there were further, more aberrant deaths. 'There is a custom among the Rajputs of Hindustan,' wrote Abu'l Fazl, 'called jauhar: in such situations wood, cotton, chips, oil and the like are piled together, and the women, willingly or unwillingly, are burned.' In Chauragarh fortress, the fire blazed for four days and any woman who shirked from the flames was beheaded by two attendants assigned to this task. At the end of four days, when 'the harvest of roses had turned to ashes', two women, miraculously, were found alive, shielded by a large piece of timber. They were Rani Durgavati's sister, Kamlavati, and a princess of Puragadh. Both the women were taken to the Mughal court.

The treasure that Asaf Khan discovered at Chauragarh was staggering. It included paintings, statues inlaid with jewels, gold idols, a hundred pots of gold coins, and 1,000 elephants. So beguiling was this wealth that Asaf Khan 'sifted the dust of misfortune' over his head and sent a paltry 200 elephants to Akbar, burying the rest of the treasure for himself. When Akbar learnt of this dishonesty, Abu'l Fazl tells us that he 'disregarded the objects and overlooked his treachery'. However, it is more likely that at only twenty-two years of age, Akbar did not think he was strong enough to censure all who defied him, and preferred to allow Asaf Khan to believe he still enjoyed the Padshah's confidence. 'He never gave anybody the chance to understand rightly his inmost sentiments,' Daniello Bartoli, a Jesuit writer, would write later about Akbar, '…a man apparently free from mystery or guile, as honest and candid as could be imagined: but in reality, so close and self-contained, with twists of words and deeds so divergent one